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IMPACT

Lawmakers Introduce Multiple Laws to Curb Flock After 404 Media Coverage



JOSEPH COX • OCT 6, 2026 AT 9:24 AM

Senator Bernie Sanders, Representative Ocasio-Cortez, and Senator Jeff Merkley introduced the Ban Flock Act on Friday, which would stop federal agencies from using automatic license plate readers.



IMAGE: SPUMONI COOPERATIVE FOR 404 MEDIA.

Multiple Democrat, Republican, and Independent lawmakers have introduced new pieces of legislation that, if passed, would dramatically curb federal agencies' access to Flock cameras, with the lawmakers referencing reporting by 404 Media in their explanations for why the legislation is needed.

On Friday Senator Bernie Sanders (I-Vt.), Representative Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez (D-N.Y.), and Senator Jeff Merkley (D-Ore.) announced the Ban Flock Act, which would prohibit federal agencies from using automatic license plate readers (ALPRs) and block federal funding from state and local governments that use the cameras. It would also let Americans sue the federal government for violation of their rights through ALPRs.

"At a time of growing concern about the unchecked power of artificial

thousands of cameras in communities across America without their consent," Sanders said in the announcement posted to his website. "Going to the doctor? Flock knows. Dropping your kid off at school? Flock is tracking you. Flock is always watching. We cannot allow America to become a surveillance state where a handful of AI oligarchs profit by giving the government the power to track our every movement."



Do you know anything else about Flock? I would love to hear from you. Using a non-work device, you can message me securely on Signal at joseph.404 or send me an email at joseph@404media.co.

Ocasio-Cortez said, "AI-powered cameras are keeping track of our every move and weaponizing this data against working people to make record profits. The widespread integration of this technology into American society is unconscionable." Merkley added, "No one should have this unchecked surveillance power at their fingertips, which is why I'm teaming up with Senator Sanders to rein in this dangerous technology."

Sanders' announcement says that one reason for the legislation is Flock has shared state information with federal immigration officials. In May 2025, 404 Media revealed local cops were doing lookups in Flock for Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE). After that report, Flock made dramatic changes to its product, including stopping other agencies searching cameras in Illinois, California, and Virginia. Flock said it also introduced a new tool that blocks impermissible searches in real time.

The announcement also said law enforcement have used Flock data to investigate protests against ICE raids and 'No Kings' demonstrations. 404 Media revealed both of these, reporting [that California cops investigated an "immigration protest" using Flock lookups](#), and, using data from the Electronic Frontier Foundation, that [cops used Flock to monitor No Kings protests around the country](#). 404 Media also recently reported Flock itself [taught cops how to surveil No Kings protesters in a company webinar](#).

Hajar Hammado, senior policy advisor at activist and progressive policy group Demand Progress, [said in a press release](#) "The Ban Flock Act is the gold standard for any legislation working to fight invasive Flock cameras on the federal level. Flock and other ALPR companies have wormed their way into communities across the nation and drastic, all-encompassing action is needed to root them out."

Senator Josh Hawley (R-Mo.) [announced his own piece of proposed legislation](#)

process for each search; force agencies to delete driver data after ten days, with exceptions for active investigations; and ban ALPR networks from incorporating facial recognition technology. During a recent senate hearing, Hawley pointed to [404 Media's reporting specifically](#).

Separately, Representatives Greg Casar and Shontel Brown recently wrote to FBI Director Kash Patel asking how the agency plans to acquire nationwide access to ALPR data, [Semafor reported](#). [404 Media first revealed](#) this plan in May. The letter also referenced [404 Media's reporting](#) which revealed a cop in Texas used Flock to search ALPRs nationwide for a woman who self-administered an abortion.

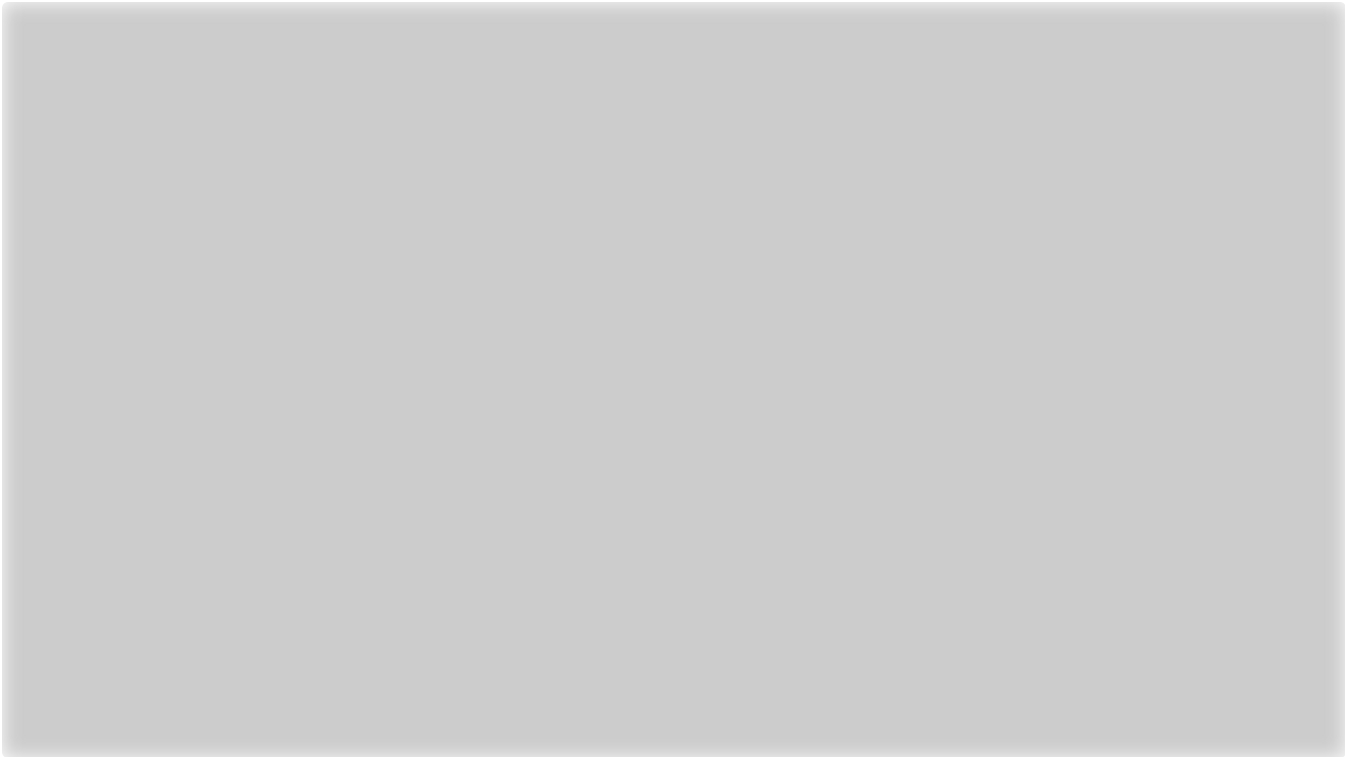
ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Joseph is an award-winning investigative journalist focused on generating impact. His work has triggered hundreds of millions of dollars worth of fines, shut down tech companies, and much more.



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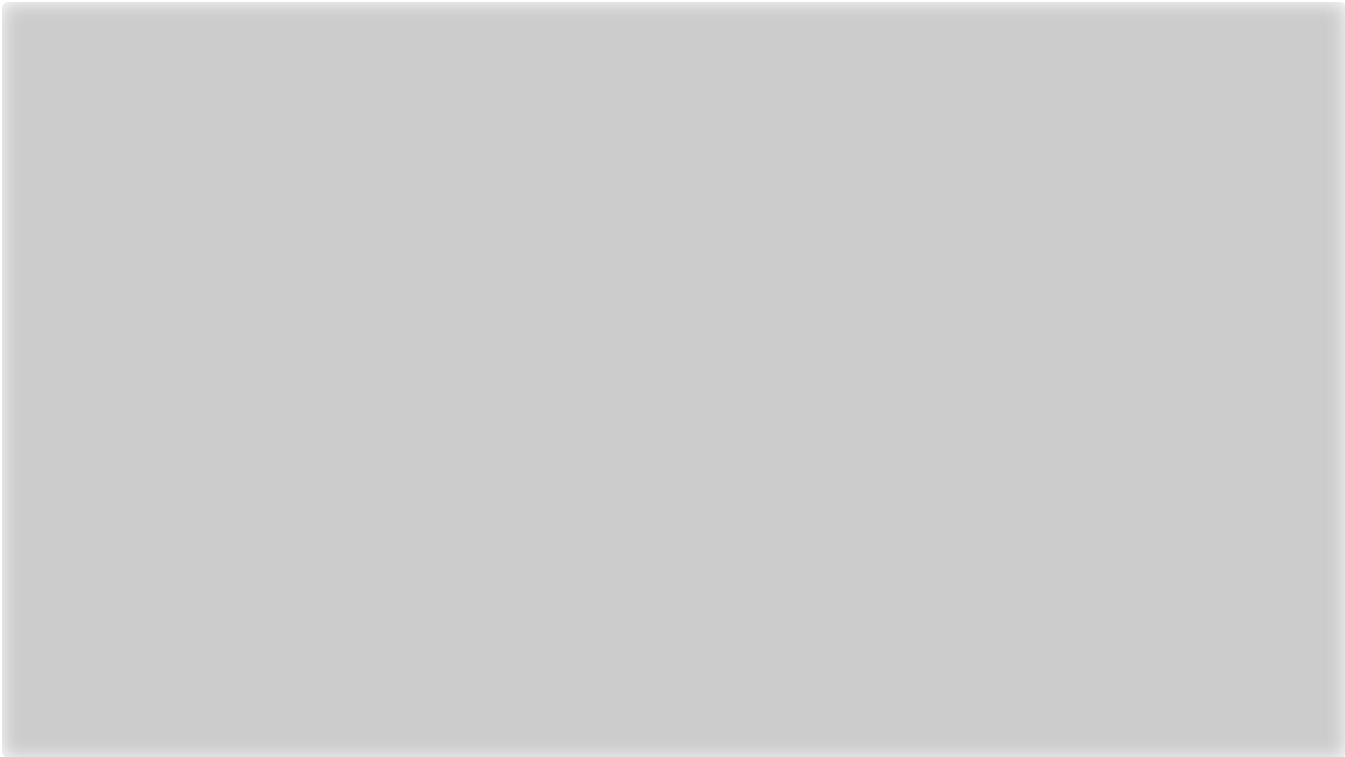
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404 Media is an independent media company founded by technology journalists Jason Koebler, Emanuel Maiberg, Samantha Cole, and Joseph Cox.

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